The events of the past few weeks have been a testing time for the country's ruling party, what with the crony capitalism charges against the Adanis and a damning BBC documentary on the 2002 Gujarat riots. But, as always, the fightback has been led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself, starting off with his speeches in both houses of Parliament during the motion of thanks to the President's address. Political analysts have focused on one line from it—*"Desh dekh raha hai, ek akela kitnon pe bhari padh raha hai* (The country is watching how one man alone has taken on so many)"—to get a sense of the course the PM's party, the Bharatiya Janata Party, is likely to take in the run-up to the 2024 general election. The vaunted BJP poll machine is a feat in itself, but they believe it'll finally boil down to how well the party can sell the 'Modi vs the Others' narrative if it is to get a third consecutive term in power.

A few days before the Hindenburg report on Adani Entreprises created havoc, the INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation survey saw PM Modi's approval ratings at a high of 72 per cent. The same survey suggested that the BJP may bag 284 seats in the 543-member lower house of Parliament if elections were to be held today. Riding on this, the BJP leadership has set an improbable target for itself, crossing the halfway mark on the vote share tab in 2024, a feat no political party has managed in all these years. In 2019, the BJP had got 37.3 per cent of the popular vote. That belief, though, may have taken a slight hit after the Hindenburg report on Adani and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's pointed attacks in Parliament, which necessitated PM Modi's rejoinder.

DRESS REHEARSAL

Before the general election, however, the dominant party in the country has to navigate a series of state polls. Its performance here will set the template for 2024, inasmuch as keeping the BJP cadre on a high or seeing a resurgent opposition knocking on its doors. The test has already begun, with the BJP trying to defend its territory in the Northeast as Tripura kickstarted poll season on February 17. It's a state the BJP is pushing hard to retain, as it had been wrested from their ideological opponents, the Left (it's been an uphill struggle in other states with Communist influence such as Kerala and West Bengal), after overturning the 25-year-old CPI(M) regime led by Manik Sarkar in 2018. The party isn't holding out much hope in Meghalaya and Nagaland, though, which go to the polls on February 27. In Meghalaya, erstwhile ally Conrad Sangma and his National People's Party (NPP) have decided to go it alone, having earlier exited the BJP-anchored North Eastern Democratic Alliance (NEDA). The party is playing second fiddle to Neiphiu Rio's Nationalist Democratic Progressive Party (NDPP) in Nagaland.

The results in these states may not have much of an impact on national political equations as together they send just five MPs, of which the BJP currently has two, two are from allies and Vincent Pala is the lone Congress lawmaker. However, any gains in these states will help erase some of the anti-minority stigma hanging over the party; Meghalaya and Nagaland have overwhelmingly Christian populations.

Coming back to the focus states, the party will get a chance to fine-tune caste equations and other permutations in six states that are headed for the polls—Karnataka, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Mizoram. Mizoram is the only state in the Northeast where the party is yet to be part of a government. In Telangana, the party is trying to position itself as the principal opposition. Among the other four, the party is the incumbent in Karnataka and MP while it will be the principal opponent in Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. The last four states are crucial for 2024 as together they account for 96 seats, of which the BJP had won 90 in 2019.

The biggest worry for the party in these states is intra-party factionalism. In Rajasthan, the BJP is already doing some 'surgery' to sort this out. Former chief minister Vasundhara Raje, 69, may not be the central leadership's favourite but it seems like she could be the frontrunner again to lead the party cam-

APPEALING TO THE MASSES

THE HIGH POINTS

- **NATIONALISM**: Tough stand on Pakistan, taking on China, leadership role in the world, including presiding over G20 this year
- **HINDUTVA:** Ram Mandir, abrogation of Article 370, relentless on love jihad, leaders like Adityanath and Himanta Sarma along with PM Modi
- **INCLUSIVE:** Party has shed image of being a Brahmin-Baniya party
- **MUSLIM ASSIMILATION:** Targeting OBC/ Dalit section of community, opening doors for Pasmanda Muslims
- **PRO-POOR:** Social schemes benefitting all even in non-BJP states
- **PRO-DEVELOPMENT:** Reforms push, construction of highways and upgradation of railways a push towards a brighter future

THE PITFALLS

- ↘ Anti-incumbency against some MPs
- ↘ Too dependent on PM Modi; local satraps are missing/ weak
- ↘ Opposition unity is difficult, but not impossible
- ↘ Unemployment remains massive challenge, unrest among young voters visible
- ↘ 2024 might be PM Modi's last poll, considering the 75-year retirement age. No succession planning